

HOUSING FIRST, HUMAN DIGNITY

Synthesizing multi-part research on homelessness drivers, systems, and solutions.

650k+

people experienced homelessness on a single January 2023 night — a 12% jump (HUD AHAR).

\$28.58/hr

wage needed for a modest 2-bedroom home; nearly double the federal minimum (NLIHC).

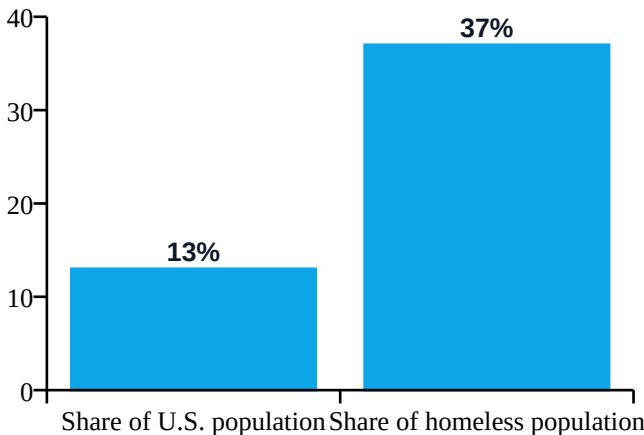
37% vs 13%

Black Americans' share of homelessness vs share of U.S. population (NAEH).

"Homelessness is not a personal failure; it signals where housing, health, and wage systems are fraying."

— Synthesized from HUD, NLIHC, and lived community observations

Racial disparities make homelessness an equity crisis



Black residents are 13% of the U.S. population yet 37% of the unhoused — evidence that structural racism shapes housing outcomes.

PROBLEM DEFINITION & EVIDENCE

- Homelessness rose 12% year-over-year, topping 650,000 people nationwide, with rents outrunning wages and vouchers stuck on multi-year waitlists.
- New Jersey's Point-in-Time count logged 12,000+ people unhoused on a single night, underscoring the regional urgency.
- Housing costs now require \$28.58/hour for a modest 2-bedroom, far beyond most renter incomes.

COMMUNITY IMPACT

- Unsheltered neighbors rely on emergency rooms, policing, and crisis systems, inflating public costs while leaving trauma unaddressed.
- Children experiencing homelessness face disrupted schooling and long-term earnings losses, perpetuating intergenerational poverty.
- Racial inequities are stark: Black residents are almost three times more likely to be unhoused than their share of the population.

KEY ACTORS & ROLES

- HUD + USICH fund Continuum of Care networks and Housing First pilots, while advocacy groups like NAEH and NLIHC reframe homelessness as a systems issue.
- NJ's Office of Homelessness Prevention aligns HPRP, SRAP, and shelter grants; new laws embed mental health providers inside shelters.
- Local governments, nonprofits, and health systems deliver day-to-day outreach, yet face funding volatility, staffing shortages, and coordination gaps.

POLICY CONTEXT & CONSTRAINTS

- McKinney-Vento and the HEARTH Act established coordinated entry and Housing First, but appropriations lag behind need.
- Section 8, LIHTC, and NJ's SRAP are lifelines but are over-subscribed; anti-camping ordinances criminalize survival instead of solving housing gaps.
- Paperwork, Medicaid billing rules, and uneven municipal priorities slow down service delivery and data sharing.

CHALLENGES ON THE GROUND

- Homelessness is a "wicked problem" tied to labor markets, healthcare capacity, criminal justice reentry, and housing production bottlenecks.
- Shelters can feel unsafe or overly rigid, pushing people back outside; deinstitutionalization without investments left many without care.
- Short-term aid cycles clients through recurring crises, while NIMBYism resists siting new supportive or deeply affordable housing.

PROPOSED SOLUTIONS & NEXT STEPS

- Scale Housing First with permanent supportive housing plus wraparound behavioral health and employment navigation.
- Expand affordable housing supply through local trust funds, rent-capped units, voucher portability, and public housing reinvestment.
- Invest upstream: eviction defense (CEDD), flexible cash aid, hospital/jail discharge planning, and decriminalized outreach responses.